wanted persons from all over Pakistan, mainly due to the lack of police and courts jurisdiction in this area. The earliest jihadist in this area was Syed Ahmed Barelvi, who chose this area to wage jihad, because the absence of government provided what we would now call a 'safe haven'. Therefore, it has a long history of serving as a safe haven, and only the actors and factors kept changing.

The collateral damage caused by the US aerial bombing in Afghanistan in 2001 resulted in so much sympathy for the Taliban and Afghans in FATA and the rest of Pakistan that the Afghan refugees, Taliban or non-Taliban were welcomed for shelter. It was a new phase of the old norm practiced since the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan.[2]

Approximately 5,000 foreigners, Uzbeks, Chechens and Arabs settled in FATA after the Afghan jihad. They contributed significantly in infecting FATA with extremist sentiments.[3] There were also other foreign militant groups such as networks of Chechens, the Libyan Islamic Fighting Group (LIFG), Chinese Uighur militants from the East Turkestan Islamic Movement (ETIM) and the Islamic Movement of Uzbekistan.

FATA had been the most underdeveloped area in Pakistan. It had the highest percentage of food-insecure population (67.7 per cent), with South Waziristan, Orakzai Agency, North Waziristan and Mohmand Agency being the worst food-insecure areas. The super flood hit South Waziristan, Orakzai and Mohmand Agency in 2010, which further deteriorated the situation (*The News International*, 2010). This deprivation and socio-economic problems were fully exploited by Al Qaeda and TTP to raise the local helpers.[4]

While Al Qaeda and Taliban were sneaking into this area, making permanent bases here and the local Taliban/militants were ganging up, the intelligence and security agencies of Pakistan remained a silent spectator and failed to perceive the threat these groups were going to pose to Pakistan and the Western world in the near future.

The situation in FATA fast deteriorated as the 'war on terror' in that area made the poor even poorer. Neglect nettled the inhabitants of FATA and during military operations no relief was given to them. The members of parliament from FATA, instead of looking after their people, abandoned the area and moved to safe places far from their constituencies. They were neither consulted when the military operations were launched in FATA nor paid heed to during distribution of funds under the budget.